

Tech Workers Ethical Considerations

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Tech workers navigate a complex relationship between the competing demands of stakeholders, coworkers, and family members, all while working to act ethically in their roles. HCI research has shown that there are many ways that unethical design can hurt and limit certain voices, however, less attention has been paid to the confluence of factors that constrain tech workers' ability to design ethically. This paper investigates how tech workers see, understand, and react to perceived ethical issues. This study presents preliminary findings from semi-structured interviews conducted between February and May 2026 with seven individuals who identify as tech workers. We present the breadth of ethical considerations across individual, company, industry, and societal levels of analysis. We discuss ethical considerations as a result of both individual actions and perceptions, and as a larger system of agency under a capitalist society. GenAI tools were not used to prepare this manuscript

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; **Collaborative and social computing**; • **Social and professional topics** → *Codes of ethics*.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: social impact; ethics of labor; qualitative interview study

ACM Reference Format:

Anonymous Author(s). 2026. Tech Workers Ethical Considerations. In *Proceedings of (Anonymous Submission)*. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 6 pages. <https://doi.org/XXXXXXX.XXXXXXX>

Authorship Notice: All text displayed in this color was written by Jonathan Leuenberger.

1 Intro

Large-scale data-driven technologies increasingly structure social, economic, and political life. Systems that collect, store, and analyze data are now central to domains including governance, security, labor, health, urban planning, and consumer services. These technologies collect, sort, and act upon data, mediating how travelers cross borders, how patients receive care, how workers are scheduled, how citizens are surveilled, and how wars are waged.

Such technologies are produced and maintained through the everyday work of *tech workers*, who operate within specific organizational, economic, and regulatory contexts themselves. Tech workers occupy a unique position; their daily decisions cascade into systems that shape how millions of people are seen, sorted, and acted upon. Yet they themselves work under conditions that shape how they can act.

Through interviews with tech workers across government contracting, defense, biomedical data, and enterprise software, we ask: (1) *how do tech workers perceive ethical considerations in tech work?* and (2) *how do tech workers consider the social impact of their work?*

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ACM ISBN 978-x-xxxx-xxxx-x/YYYY/MM

<https://doi.org/XXXXXXX.XXXXXXX>

We address these questions through semi-structured interviews conducted between February and May 2026 with workers across a range of technical roles at a variety of public and private institutions spanning government contracting and defense, the biomedical and healthcare industries, data infrastructure, and enterprise software.

Our findings provide insight into how tech workers relate, understand, and navigate different levels of ethical considerations. We contend that unethical design is an outcome of layered structural conditions: hierarchies that push moral accountability upward, labor markets that make individual refusal feel futile, and institutional environments that prioritize data collection and profit over ethical deliberation.

2 Related Work

Recent work in HCI, CSCW, and STS has shifted attention toward the designers, engineers, operators, and intermediaries who make these technologies function in practice. Studies have found that in technology development, there is often minimal allowance for ethical considerations. For example, with the increased commonality of Artificial Intelligence (AI), questions have been raised about which ethical issues are being considered, yet Vakkuri et al. found that often none were considered [7]. Further, when designers brought up ethical concerns, they were often not supported, and no change was made [8]. The tech industry enforces a habitus that forces tech workers to feel as though they are alone with their ethical concerns [6]. Thus, studies have shifted into developing procedures and ways to help tech workers both identify ethical concerns [1], and build tech workers' collective power in addressing ethical concerns [8].

HCI as a field is concerned with the designer, the technology, and the end user; it is this interplay of foci that position HCI to have large social impacts [3]. Yet, there is a notable lack of research and design practices that understand the late-stage capitalist society [5] in which technology companies operate, where the drive to innovate and develop better and faster technologies often outweighs the cost to the end user. Our paper addresses the issue of designers working within systems that prohibit, deny, and erase instances of ethical consideration, and provides a framework to address the constraints our society places on social considerations, juxtaposed with the bolstering of innovation.

3 Methods

We conducted seven remote, semi-structured interviews with people who identified as being tech workers. The first three authors conducted the interviews between February and April of 2026. We recruited participants using social media posts to general tech worker forums (Reddit, Mastodon), and personal professional networks (LinkedIn, BlueSky, Professional Slack, and Discord Channels). Recruitment posts focused on asking tech workers about the social impact of their work and included a form to coordinate participation and get a high-level understanding of the work.

Our participants all identified as being tech workers whose main source of data involved either people or environments, spoke English, and were at least 18 years of age. All of our participants were employed within the tech industry for at least 1 year. The average interview lasted 37 minutes. The interviews focused on understanding participants': (a) perspectives on the types of ethical concerns being considered in their workplaces, (b) perceptions of the social impact of their work, and (c) considerations of the direction their industry is going in.

The audio from the remote interviews were recorded, transcribed, and verified. Drawing from Braun and Clarke [2], the full research team produced themes via qualitative thematic analysis. The first three authors engaged in open coding followed by iterative affinity diagramming [4].

In what follows, we outline our findings, structuring the common ethical considerations and themes across individual, company, industry, and societal levels of analysis.

4 Results

4.1 Individual Level

At the individual level, most participants described how financial necessity shaped their ethical decision-making in ways that constrained their individual agency. P7 articulated this directly, noting that working in the US means workers “*largely have to chase that dollar,*” sometimes working jobs that do not align with their values in exchange for better pay, benefits, and potential futures.

Most participants who experienced ethical misalignment with their workplaces sought ways to navigate those tensions. In roles where participants disagreed with their companies’ ethical standards and values, they worked to identify areas in which they felt they could still act ethically. Often this was through seeking out projects and clients that aligned with their personal values, or working on in-house tools that facilitated the organizational work (e.g., analytics, IT). P6, for instance, shared that they had yet to work with a client whose values were misaligned, but considered the scenario: “*If it were to come up in the future, I would ask if there is another consultant [who] could work on that client instead, or if some kind of switch could be made.*” Similarly, P4, who worked on aircraft technology, focused on the immediate stakeholder that their work would benefit: pilot safety and aircraft reliability. When asked about the ethical responsibility of their work, they responded, “*All I know is that I’m making these decisions for the safety of the immediate users [pilots]. There’s some degrees of separation from my usage versus the moral implications of people actually using them.*” In such cases, participants focused on immediate, tangible benefits of their work while distancing themselves from the broader consequences of how those technologies might ultimately be deployed.

4.2 Institutional Level

At the institutional level, participants’ ethical considerations centered on the organizations’ relationships with clients and the downstream implications of the technologies they helped build. A central concern was the question of *who* their work ultimately served and what those clients might do with the products once deployed. Participants expressed discomfort when their companies’ platforms were adopted by clients whose values or practices conflicted with their own. For example, P3 described discomfort with a federal agency storing data on their company’s cloud infrastructure, worrying that the platform could enable mass surveillance. P6, who works at a defense contracting company with many populist and right-wing clients, captured this tension directly: “*in my mind, that makes me wonder a little like, What does it say about us as a company if we’re not able to attract a different scale of client?*”

A contrasting strategy that emerged was the framing of the institution and its products as *inherently neutral*. In such cases, participants such as P3 would compare their work to general-purpose technologies such as word processing tools: “*Good people will use it, bad people will use it. I’m here to provide the tool.*” This orientation functions as a form of ethical insulation, allowing participants to maintain professional investment in the quality and functionality of their work while deferring moral responsibility for outcomes to actors outside of their immediate purview. In such cases, participants suspended ethical consideration instead of resolving such tensions, enabling continued commitment to their work.

4.3 Industry Level

Industry-wide, our participants noted a widespread *lack* of ethical consideration, which many felt manifested in concrete, problematic practices across the tech sector. The most prominent of these was the excessive and often unnecessary collection of data. Participants noted that the industry has normalized accumulating vast quantities of data with little justification or business need. P5

characterized this as collecting data *“for no good, for no reason because it’s not providing business”* and expressed such concern about the industry’s failure to reckon with these practices that they ruled out employment in the social media sector entirely. P7 further noted this unchecked collection creates downstream harms, as data are frequently leveraged to generate targeted advertising designed to manipulate users.

Participants also identified a lack of ethical consideration around data *access* as a driver of problematic outcomes. Without industry-wide norms or internal policies governing who can access what, workers frequently found themselves with far broader access to sensitive data than their roles warranted. P6 recounted having unintended access to student data from a school district client, a direct consequence of their company’s lacking a staging environment for testing their online forms. Participants across sectors described similar experiences. P7, a former software engineer for a county government, reflected on the absence of clear access boundaries:

[There is] definitely way too much. There wasn’t a clear and safe delineation between what should and shouldn’t be accessed and whose roles were and weren’t their responsibilities.

For P7, this absence of policy was a clear ethical failure where data were not being carefully stored and with access regulated. P7 went on to describe an incident in which a newly onboarded office failed to securely store sensitive case materials, requiring staff to conduct a manual audit to verify the data had not been compromised:

They did not secure [materials] securely, and we ultimately had to, across multiple people, do some checks across this data to make sure it hadn’t been tampered with because it had been called into question if the data was still safe.

For P7, this example is an outcome that felt preventable had greater care been taken at the industry level around the design of concrete data governance practices.

4.4 Societal Level

The predominant societal-level ethical consideration raised across interviews was the broader cultural and economic context in which technology is developed—namely, a capitalist society in which profit is the primary measure of value. Participants reflected not just on their own companies and industries, but on how this structural reality shapes what gets built, what gets protected, and what gets ignored across the technology landscape as a whole.

Nearly all participants identified the singular societal emphasis on cutting costs and revenue growth as a force that fundamentally undermines ethical considerations in tech. When financial return is the dominant social value, work that does not contribute to the bottom line is structurally devalued. P1 captured this dynamic, sharing that security improvements go unrewarded precisely because they are invisible to profit metrics: *“[Implementing] an intrusion detection system that detects an intrusion 30 seconds faster than the one that you had before doesn’t affect the bottom line.”*

For many participants, this lack of consideration for non-revenue generating work extends across industries and reflects broader societal priorities. P7 described working in an environment where the profit motive was so dominant that it directly displaced ethical considerations around security: *“It’s a very money driven thing where I’m more interested in delivering security and not necessarily interested in a bottom line.”* The tension P7 experienced was between individual ethical considerations and a societal system that does not reward it. Across participants, capitalism’s demand for continuous growth emerged as a structural condition that makes ethical consideration in tech work difficult.

5 Discussion

This work sought to understand how tech workers perceive and navigate ethical considerations across multiple levels—individual, institutional, industry-wide, and societal. Participants were attuned to ethical issues well beyond their immediate roles, situating their work within broader structural forces. Across these levels, a consistent pattern emerged: participants were rarely without ethical awareness, but were frequently without the structural support to act on it.

At the individual level, financial necessity emerged as a primary constraint on ethical agency, with participants describing how economic realities compelled them to take or remain in jobs misaligned with their values. When ethical tensions did arise, participants tended to manage rather than resolve them—narrowing their focus to immediate stakeholders, seeking out value-aligned projects, or negotiating internal transfers. At the institutional level, a similar dynamic appeared: rather than confronting ethical misalignment head-on, participants often adopted a neutrality framing, positioning themselves as providers of tools rather than agents responsible for downstream outcomes. This functioned less as a reasoned ethical position and more as a coping mechanism that allowed continued professional engagement.

At the industry and societal levels, participants shifted from describing personal navigation strategies to identifying structural failures. The normalization of excessive data collection, the absence of data governance practices, and the primacy of profit over ethical consideration were understood not as individual or company-level failures, but as features of the broader environment in which tech work takes place.

Taken together, these findings suggest that ethical consideration in tech work is not simply a matter of individual values or corporate culture, but is deeply shaped by the structural conditions—economic, institutional, and industrial—within which workers operate.

This study's primary limitation is its small sample size of seven participants, which limits the generalizability of findings. The sample also does not represent the full diversity of roles, industries, or backgrounds present in the tech sector. Future work should expand this inquiry with a larger and more diverse sample, and might use quantitative methods to assess how broadly these dynamics are experienced across the tech workforce.

6 Conclusion

This paper has shown that tech workers are not the sole actors when unethical failures take place. Ethical concerns are the product of a layered system of decision making, spanning individual, company, industry, and societal ethical issues; and are never the result of a singular worker. Our findings show that ethical tensions, like those caused by the pursuit of data collection and profit, creates structural conditions that constrain ethical action even among workers who recognize and care about the harms being done.

For HCI, these findings call for a reframing of how unethical design is understood. Unethical design is not a failure of individual consideration, but is an outcome shaped by a broader network of institutional and capitalist pressures. CSCW researchers should therefore research how these systems can be subverted and restructured to move the pressure of ethical decision making away from solely the designer to the system these individuals are embedded within.

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